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Modes of persuasion

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Local residents considered these verses to be among the most poetic and beautiful of exorcism song texts. Tina's cure was considered effective because it was dependent on the quality of the music and songs, judged harmonious with the drumming, dancing by the women in trance, her beautiful festival clothing, and applause by the audience. Audience response in particular, considered part of the musical performance, is equally crucial for the cure. In effect, the degree to which the songs are judged to be in harmony with instrumental and dancing accompaniment, as well as how much they stimulate audience applause, shouts of encouragement, joking, and play, determines the cure. The song verses must also be "well-pronounced." Taken together, all these currents must be be harmonious, "like tea is to sugar." Therein resides the power to elicit affective support from the audience, comprised of youthful men and women of diverse social segments but usually close friends and cousins of the possessed woman.

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Upon conclusion of the singing, audience members commented on this harmony, on the clearly-pronounced words, on the resonant drumming, and the liveliness of Tina's dancing. During gossip at evening tea-drinking sessions soon thereafter, the subject of Tina's possession recurred among mutual friends of Tina, Hadia, her mother, spouse, and myself.

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Within the song verses themselves, the abundance of rich imagery vividly conveys sentiments whose expression is normally forbidden. Tuareg believe that the liver is the seat of sentiments, and that spirits occupy it before climbing up into the head and affecting the memory. The problem, then, is what sentiments these are, to whom they are forbidden, toward whom they are directed, how, and why. The second wife among Kel Ewey, who usually resides at a distance from her co-wife, is often neglected and less well-cared for economically by the husband. The song's metaphors refer to water and milk; salted meat in the mouth; and the stitched cloth bands made into blankets used to cushion camels' backs on caravans. "Well-attached branches of the tent" refers to the summit of forked branches of the central post of the tent, erected at the wedding by close female relatives of the bride, and brought by the Tuareg bride to her marriage as her own property, from which she may eject her husband upon quarreling or divorce. But the problem for women is that bridewealth livestock is held in trust for them by first, their father, and later, the husband, and may revert to the husband if the marabout rules in the latter's favor upon divorce. Thus while an important source of women's power is their control over residential property, their access to resources in herds is limited. However, there is continuing support from the matriline throughout marriage, particularly, in the early years during uxorilocal residence, when the new husband must provide his affines with labor, millet, and household goods. Before the marriage is considered stable, and the couple given permission to move, the husband must please his parents-in-law, in particular the mother-in-law. The mother-in-law and older females in the bride's family construct the nuptial tent which becomes the married woman's property. The new groom only comes there to sleep, after sundown (in the case of a polygynist, of course, visits take place only some evenings). Furthermore, Tina's husband had additional reason for concern about his reputation because part of his claims to success depended upon outward show of generosity; Tuareg view economic prosperity as accompanied by obligations to be generous. So the metaphors evoke a convergence of continued integration and moral support for the women by her own family and the matriline after her marriage in times of conflict. The married woman can count on the solidarity of matrifocal household members, yet she cannot, for precisely this same reason, afford to antagonize them.

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Thus there is a delicate balance and contradiction here. Since many parents encourage polygynous matches because male polygynists tend to be wealthier, poorer families experience conflict between traditional Tuareg cultural values favoring monogamy and recent pressure to find eligible suitors for their daughters who can provide economic security to the household. There is a convergence in this event between the imagery of the songs and the audience interaction and gossip. The possession songs enable the afflicted to rally different sources of support (in public opinion) without “burning the bridges” of long-term ties. Skill is publicly defined as fulfilling the aesthetic criteria of singing, dancing, and adornment; but underlying this is the process of persuasion. Gossip, flirting, and courtship often take place among audience members and  37 through this process the concerns of patient are transposed onto the possession event. Among the audience, both within and outside of the ritual context, there was discussion of Tina's problems. The aesthetic style, performance context, and subject matter of music and songs framed her experience in ways which evoked public sympathy. The audience continually asked Tina how she felt, if the cure was progressing, and so on.

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